



STANDING STONES

The ring of immense pillars and lintels known as Stonehenge stands at the center of a prehistoric earthwork.

Stonehenge

A unique circle of massive standing stones with mysterious symbolic significance, and perhaps the world's most famous prehistoric monument



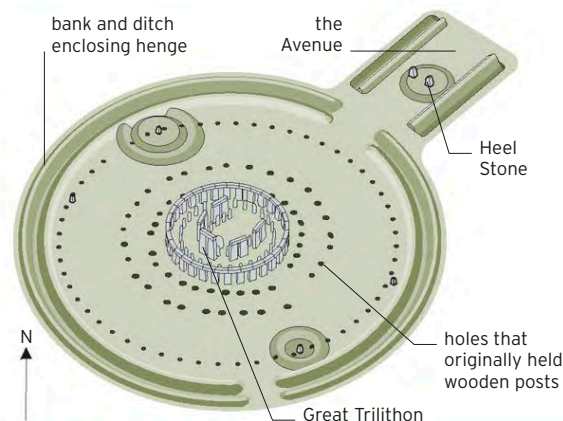
Situated on the chalk plateau of Salisbury Plain in the south of England, Stonehenge stands in a region rich in sites of archaeological interest. The monuments in the area had their beginnings thousands of years ago. In around 3100 BCE, the first earthworks were begun in the form of a “henge”—an area enclosed within a circular ditch and bank. In around 3000 BCE, a wooden structure was erected within the henge and used for ceremonial cremation. The stone monument began to take shape in about 2500 BCE. Eighty bluestone pillars were erected, and a huge sandstone “Altar Stone” was laid at the center of the henge. Later, the massive sarsen (dense sandstone) blocks replaced or were added to the pillars to form the present structure—a circle of 30 upright stones and lintels around a central horseshoe-shaped group of trilithons aligned with the Sun at the solstices.

Ceremonies for the dead

Scholars remain uncertain about the function of the henge. It is likely to have had a calendrical function and been used as a ceremonial and burial site, as evident from the discovery of many cremated bones at the site.

Each of the **sarsen blocks** weighed up to **33 tons (30 tonnes)**

SOLAR ALIGNMENT



A processional approach to Stonehenge, known as the Avenue, leads from the River Avon 1.5 miles (2.5 km) away. The final stretch is aligned with the axis of the stone circle, so that when entering from the Avenue at sunrise on the summer solstice and sunset on the winter solstice, the Sun can be seen through the central Great Trilithon. The so-called Heel Stone at the main entrance is assumed to have originally been one of a pair forming a sort of gateway through which processions would have passed.